

Report Writing

A report is a more highly structured form of writing than an essay and is designed so that it can be read quickly and accurately. Reports should be organised for the convenience of the intended reader. Reports are written on a wide range of subjects for a wide variety of reasons. All reports attempt to communicate findings for one reason or another, whether to inform decision makers, change public opinion or maintain a record of development.

Some of the characteristics of reports are:

- Reports typically travel upward in an organisation because they usually are requested by a higher authority.
- Reports are logically organised.
- Reports are objective- As reports contribute to decision making and problem solving, they should be as objective as possible.
- Reports are generally prepared for a limited audience- This characteristic is particularly true of reports travelling within an organisation, and means that reports like letters, memos and emails can be prepared with the receivers needs in mind.

Types of Reports

Based on the four characteristics, a workable definition of a report is an orderly, objective message used to convey information from one organisational area to another, or from one organisation to another to assist in decision making or problem solving. Reports have been classified in numerous ways by management and by report preparation authorities. The form, direction, functional use and content of the report are used as bases for classification.

- Formal or informal reports- The formal or informal classification is particularly helpful because it applies to all reports. A formal report is carefully structured; it is logically organised and objective, contains much detail, and is written in a style that tends to eliminate such elements as personal pronouns. An informal report is usually a short message written in natural or personal language. An internal memo generally can be described as an informal report.

- Short or long reports- Reports can be classified as short or long. A one-page memo is obviously short and a report of twenty pages is long. As it becomes longer, a report takes on more characteristics of formal reports. Thus, the classification of formal or informal and short or long reports are closely related.
- Informational or analytical reports- An informational report carries objective information from one area of an organisation to another. Company annual reports, monthly financial statements, reports of sales volume and reports of employee or personnel absenteeism and turnover are informational reports. An analytical report presents suggested solutions to problems. Reports of scientific research, real estate appraisal reports, and feasibility reports by consulting firms are analytical reports.
- Vertical or lateral reports- The vertical or lateral classification refers to the directions in which reports travel. Although most reports travel upward in organisations, many travel downward. Both represent vertical reports and are often referred to as upward-directed and downward-directed reports. Lateral reports, on the other hand, assist in coordination in the organisation. A report travelling between units on the same organisational level, as between the production department and the finance department, is lateral.
- Internal or external reports- An internal report, such as a production or sales report, travels within an organisation. An external report, such as company's annual report to stockholders, is prepared for distribution outside an organisation.
- Periodic reports- Periodic reports are issued on regularly scheduled dates. They are generally directed upward and serve management control purposes. Daily, weekly, monthly, quarterly, semi-annual and annual time periods are typical of periodic reports.
- Functional reports- A functional report serves a specified purpose within a company. The functional classification includes accounting reports, marketing reports, financial reports, personnel reports and a variety of other reports that take their functional designation from their ultimate use.

Parts of a formal report

Reports serve up variety of purposes, so the type of report you prepare depends on the subject matter, the purpose of the report and the readers' needs. The differences between a formal report and an informal report lie in the format and possibly in the writing style. At one extreme, a brief, informal report could look exactly like a brief memorandum. At the other, a highly

formal report might include many elements. Not all reports contain all these parts, however: some parts may be missing. The order in which these parts are presented may also vary sometimes according to the need of the organization.

i) Preliminary Parts

Title page -Includes title, author, date and frequently the name of the person or organization that requested the report; adds formality.

Authorization – Provides written authorization to complete report.

Transmittal- Presents report to reader and summarizes main points or analysis.

Table of contents – Provides overview of report and order in which information will be presented; contains headings on page numbers.

Table of figures- Includes number, title and page number of tables and graphics

Executive summary- summarizes essential elements in report

ii) Report Text

Introduction – Orients reader to topic and previews major divisions.

Body – Presents information collected.

Analysis- Reviews main points presented in body and may include conclusions and recommendations.

iii) Addenda

References – Includes an alphabetical listing of the sources used in preparing the report that is included at the end of the report

Appendixes- a section placed at the end of the report that contains supplementary information that supports the report, but is not appropriate for inclusion in the report itself as it would make the report bulky and unmanageable

Index – Includes an alphabetical guide to the subject matter in a report.

Bibliography – A list at the end of the report that includes sources not cited in the report.

Short Reports

Short reports incorporate many of the same organizational strategies as do long reports. However, most short reports include only the minimum supporting materials to achieve effective communication. Short reports focus on the body - problem, method findings and conclusion. Certain features of short reports are:-

- Personal writing style using first or second person
- Contractions when they contribute to a natural style
- Graphics to reinforce the written text

- Headings and sub headings to partition portions of the body and to reflect organization
- Memorandum, email, and letter formats when appropriate

Memorandum, email and letter reports

Short reports are often written in memorandum, email or letter format. The memorandum report is directed to an organizational insider, as our most email reports. The letter report is directed to a reader outside the organization. Memoranda or 'Memos' are brief and informal written notes addressed to individuals or groups. They are usually internal (addressed to members of the same organization as the writer) but can sometimes be external. They may be sent through 'internal mail' (in the form of written messages, in 'hard copy'), the 'intranet' (local, closed-circuit computer networks, in 'soft copy'), or the internet. Memos are usually treated as 'routine correspondence', communicating factual information, announcements, proposals, inquiries, requests etc. Because of their short length and informal style, they usually produce a neutral to slightly positive response from the reader and so adopt a fairly direct approach. The bottom line is made to stand out prominently and sometimes this is all that the communication contains.

Here is an example of a memo.

(Logo) **ARTEL BUSINESS SOLUTIONS**

Internal memo

TO All members of the Sales Promotion Group

FROM GM Marketing

DATE 07 October 2008-12-08

SUBJECT Meeting of the SPG on October 12 to discuss new marketing strategy

I am calling a meeting of the SPG at 10.30 hours on Monday, 12 October, in the Conference Room. Please make it a point to attend and cancel any other engagements that you may have made.

As you are aware, the sales of our new Oriya word-processing package, Srilekha, have been disappointing, although it has received CDAC certification. We need to develop a new marketing

strategy. Let us discuss this at the meeting.

Please give the matter some serious thought and come with your suggestions. This has to be a collective effort.

Samples of business reports/ reports

1 Internal informational report (memo format)

UNITEL COMMUNICATIONS

INTERNAL MEMO

TO Director HRD

FROM Regional Manager, Madhya Pradesh

DATE 05 September 2008-12-15

SUBJECT High absenteeism in Dewas branch

Absenteeism figures in our Dewas branch were unusually high during August this year. On average, about 25 percent of the employees were absent from the office on any given day.

The reason most commonly stated was lack of convenient transport. Employees living in outlying areas are often unable to come to the office as bus services in Dewas are irregular.

I have contacted the Manager of the local transport company who has promised to provide additional buses on this route.

This is for your information.

2 Internal analytical report (memo format)

SPECTRAVISION ELECTRONICS

Internal memo

TO Chief Marketing Manager

FROM Ravi Kumar, Deputy Manager, Lucknow Region

DATE 22 June 2007

SUBJECT Declining sales of TVL refrigerators

1 During the first quarter of 2007, we sold 4600 units of TVL refrigerators imported from China.

Sales figures during the current quarter have been disappointing, however. To date, we have sold only 2200 units -- a decline of nearly 60 percent.

2 My sales staff and I have conducted an informal customer survey during the past three months to find out the reason. We were able to contact about 800 of the customers, mostly from rural areas, who bought TVL refrigerators from us. 65 percent of them reported frequent breakdown of the compressor units. Replacements are not readily available as spares have to be imported. Customers said, however, that they find the prices very attractive.

3 The importers in Mumbai may be asked to improve the supply of compressor units to regional distributors or sales may go down further.

3 External informational report (letter format)

VIDARBHA VANIJYA BANK

NAGPUR 513260

25 February 2008

Dear Customer

We are happy to announce that the Vidarbha Vanijya Bank, which has its head-office in Nagpur,

is planning to start operations in Orissa very soon. Our first branch in Bhubaneswar will be inaugurated by the Hon'ble Chief Minister of Orissa on 15 September 2008.

The Vidarbha Vanijya Bank was started in the year 1916 in Nagpur by Sri Parvez Personji, a distinguished industrialist and banker. It was launched with a seed capital of only Rs.1.00 lakhs, but today the total business of the bank is worth Rs 22,000 crores. Our total deposits as on 31.12.2007 stood at Rs. 12,549 crores and total advances at Rs. 9528 crores.

The bank has a Credit Adequacy Ratio of 12.58 percent as against the RBI stipulated norm of nine percent.

The bank has lowest NPA ratios in the country at 0.18 percent.

Over the past 4 years, the bank has declared over 100 percent dividends.

Our vision is to serve our customers by delivering innovative products and services at affordable rates, through a country-wide branch network.

We look forward to receiving your patronage. For more information about the bank and its products, please log on to : [www.vvb. Co.in](http://www.vvb.co.in)

Yours sincerely,

(signed) G.M. Patel

Managing Director

Figure 12-5 Short Report in Expanded Letter Format, Page 1 of 4

SPL STRATEGIC SOLUTIONS
761 Westgate Avenue Atlanta, GA 30319-8718 (404)555-1768 Fax (404)555-6221

Management Consulting and Corporate Training

April 3, 2008

Ms. Jill A. Rowland
President, MetroBank
1660 Fremont Street
Marietta, GA 30360-1660

Dear Ms. Rowland:

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR IMPLEMENTING A RETURN TO CONSERVATIVE BUSINESS DRESS POLICY

Thank you for allowing us to assist you in determining whether to implement a return to conservative business dress policy for MetroBank employees. This trend is gaining wide support throughout the business community and deserves careful consideration by your organization.

Procedures

In preparing this report, a variety of resources were consulted, including paper and online resources. Additionally, interviews were conducted with 20 businesspersons from a variety of organizations in Texas that have returned to business dress policies. Their perceptions, along with published research on the advantages and disadvantages of the strategy, led to the recommendations in this report. Published resources, as well as firsthand interviews, generally support the implementation of a return to a business dress policy.

Findings

Research revealed useful information concerning the development and current status of business attire.

Trend from Casual Back to Conservative Business Attire

The casual dress movement gained rapid momentum in the 1990s, spurred by the casual dot-com heyday. In 1992, only 24 percent of businesses surveyed by the Society for Human Resource Management allowed casual attire at the office, and nearly 75 percent of those permitted it on just one day of the week. By 1999, 95 percent of employers surveyed by the same group had a dress-casual policy, and more than 40 percent of those businesses permitted it every workday (White, 2001).

Advocates pushing a decade ago to loosen dress codes claimed that more casual, comfortable wear at the office would mean happier employees who would work harder and produce more than they would cinched up in buttoned-down collars, ties, and suits. While casually clad employees did enjoy new-found freedom and comfort, much research and anecdotal evidence has indicated "that relaxed dress leads to relaxed manners, relaxed morals, and relaxed productivity" (Hudson, 2002, p. 6). A 1999 study by the employment law firm Jackson Lewis found that casual clothes could lead to increased on-the-job flirting, harassment, tardiness, and absenteeism (White, 2001). Furthermore, problems with dress-down policies frequently resulted from the lack of clear standards as to what constituted business casual (Jones, 2003).

• Letterhead, letter address, and subject line function as title page and transmittal.

• Uses deductive approach to present main idea to president.

• Provides research methods and sources to add credibility.

• Uses centered heading to denote major division of body; transition sentence leads reader to subpoint denoted by its own heading.

Format Pointer
Uses subject line to introduce topic of letter report.

Figure 12-5 Short Report in Expanded Letter Format, Page 2 of 4

- Includes second page heading to show continuation; appears on plain matching paper.

- Uses side heading to denote minor section.

- Uses transition sentence to move reader smoothly to minor section.

- Provides APA citations for direct quotes and paraphrased information.

- Uses side heading and transition sentence to move reader smoothly to minor section.

- Uses bullets to highlight advantages of business dress.

Ms. Jill A. Rowland

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Implementation of Conservative Business Dress in Other Organizations

Following the lax dress policies of the past, more companies are tightening their dress policies by bringing back business professional attire. Some attribute the shift to the Bush administration. Within days of his inauguration in 2001, President George W. Bush announced a new formal dress code that reinstated the business suit as appropriate office attire and banned jeans and T-shirts from White House business meetings. The reason, he said, was to restore dignity and sobriety to the office of the presidency (Brody, 2003). In the same year, various firms reversed their business-casual dress policies, including Bear Stearns, Deutsche Bank, and Lehman Brothers.

A 2002 survey commissioned by the Men's Apparel Alliance showed that 19 percent of over 200 companies with more than \$500 million in annual revenues were returning to formal business attire (Egodigwe & Alleyne, 2003). A 2003 survey by Kurt Salmon Associates revealed that only 24 percent of all businesses currently offered casual days—down from 87 percent in 2000 during the height of the trend (Brody, 2003).

Although most employees understand terms such as "business dress" and "business professional," others may need more graphic definitions, such as "traditional suits and ties" (Brody, 2003, p. 7). In reversing its business casual policy, Lehman Brothers detailed its requirements in a memo to employees. "Business dress for men is a suit and tie, and for women, a suit with either a skirt or slacks, a dress, or other equivalent attire" (Egodigwe & Alleyne, 2003, p. 59). Many find the new requirements much more straightforward than the vagary of business casual. A paralegal of a law firm reversing its business casual dress code expressed relief at the elimination of confusion: "Now I don't have to guess what I should and shouldn't wear to work" (Egodigwe & Alleyne, 2003, p. 59).

Advantages of Conservative Business Dress

Various positive outcomes have been attributed to the implementation of business dress policies:

- Improved attitudes. People tend to behave in ways that complement their clothing. They are more likely to act like professionals if they are wearing a suit and tie (Koestner, 2005).
- Increased productivity. Improvements in the overall quality of work, professional commitment, and company loyalty have been reported when business dress was enforced (Hudson, 2002).
- Enhanced image. The clothing people wear can affect their careers, as well as the organization's image (Best Business Attire, 2003).
- Greater versatility. The tried-and-true business uniform means that employees can go anywhere and meet anyone, knowing they are properly attired (Hudson, 2002).
- Increased respect for women and minorities. John T. Molloy, the original dress-for-success author, asserts that business attire enhances the authority of women, minorities, and short men, placing everyone on a more even playing field (Malloy, 1999).

The primary disadvantage associated with a shift to a more formal business dress policy is that some workers must purchase new wardrobe selections to comply with the business dress standard (Koestner, 2005).

Figure 12-5 Short Report in Expanded Letter Format, Page 3 of 4

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Implementation of Conservative Business Dress Policy

Establishing an official dress code is the first step in making the shift from casual to business dress. The code establishes a clear set of rules for all employees as to what is acceptable. Guidelines should be simple but specific, in writing, and well distributed; they should not conflict with Title VII of the Civil Rights Act, which protects employees' cultural and religious rights (Brody, 2003).

Because a dressier code can involve wardrobe updating, employees may need assistance in understanding fashion trends and making smart purchases. Various clothing manufacturers, retailers, and business consultants provide information and training in wardrobe selection:

Sources of Information About Conservative Business Dress

Brooks Bros.	Holds seminars and fashion shows; offers special clothing discounts through Corporate Image Program	http://www.brooksbrothers.com
Neiman Marcus	Offers instructional video on business dress	http://www.neimanmarcus.com
Dayton Hudson Corp.	Conducts fashion seminars	http://www.targetcorp.com
Men's Wearhouse	Offers free instructional video on dress for success	http://www.menswearhouse.com

- Uses three-column table to make information easy to access. Table immediately follows its introduction; is not numbered because it is only figure.

Summary

The following guidelines are offered to ensure a successful implementation of a return to a conservative business dress policy:

- Access information from organizational sources described in this report and consider consultant options.
- Appoint an employee committee to investigate the particulars of an appropriate business dress policy for MetroBank and to make a recommendation to management as to implementation guidelines.
- Consider phasing in the more formal policy, allowing time for employees to adjust their wardrobes for full implementation.
- Evaluate the success of the program from the perspectives of management, employees, and customers; make any indicated changes.

- Uses bulleted list to summarize points for emphasis.

Thank you for the opportunity to provide this information concerning a return to a conservative dress policy. Please let us know how we can assist you further with this project or with other related endeavors.

- Closes with courteous offer to provide additional service.

Sincerely,

Patricia Sykes

Patricia Sykes, Consultant
ksm

Enclosure: Reading list

- Includes enclosure notation to alert reader of enclosed reading list.

Figure 12-5 Short Report in Expanded Letter Format, Page 4 of 4

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Reading List

- Best business attire. (2003). Executive Communications Group. Retrieved May 30, 2006, from <http://ecglink.com>
- Brody, M. (2003, March 1). Dress codes: 'Business conservative' is making a comeback. *HR Briefing*, 7.
- Egodigwe, L., & Alleyne, S. (2003, March). Here come the suits. *Black Enterprise*, 33(8), 59.
- Hudson, R. (2002, April 15). 'Business casual' on the wane. *St. Louis Post Dispatch*. Retrieved May 30, 2006, from <http://seattlepi.nwsource.com>
- Jones, C. (2003, June 8). Experts discuss ways to dress in business attire for summer. *Las Vegas Review*. Retrieved May 30, 2006, from InfoTrac database.
- Koestner, M. (2005, May 7). What exactly is business casual? *The News-Herald*. Retrieved May 30, 2006, from General BusinessFile database.
- Molloy, J. T. (1999, December 9). Executives find as dress gets sloppier, attitudes slip. *The Houston Chronicle*, p. 2.
- White, R. D. (2001, August 26). Clashing dress styles. *Careerbuilder*. Retrieved June 13, 2003, from <http://www.latimes.com>

Figure 12-3 Short, Periodic Report in Memorandum Format



THE PLAY STATION (Child Care and Learning Center)
1560 Kingsbury Lane / Arlington, VA 22222 / (703)555-6412 FAX (703)555-0919

TO: Tracey E. Bricka, Director, Human Resources
FROM: Russ Huff, Coordinator, Child Care Services RH
DATE: September 14, 2008
SUBJECT: Quarterly Report on In-House Child Care Center, Second Quarter, 2008

The in-house child care center experienced a successful second quarter. Data related to enrollment and current staffing follow:

Enrollment: 92 children, up from 84 at end of first quarter.
Staff: Ten full-time staff members, including six attendants, three teachers, and one registered nurse.

Registration for the upcoming school year is presently underway and is exceeding projected figures. Current staff size will necessitate an enrollment cap of 98. Further increases in enrollment will be possible only if additional personnel are hired.

The payroll deduction method of payment, instituted on January 1, has ensured that operations remain profitable. It has also eliminated the time and expense of billing. Parents seem satisfied with the arrangement as well.

Full license renewal is expected in August as we have met and/or exceeded all state and county requirements for facilities, staff, and programs.

Favorable results were obtained from the employee satisfaction poll, which was administered to parents participating in the child care program. Ninety-one percent indicated that they were very satisfied or extremely satisfied with our in-house child care program. The most frequently mentioned suggestion for improvement was the extension of hours until 7 p.m. This change would allow employees time to run necessary errands after work, before picking up their children. We might consider this addition of services on a per-hour rate basis. A copy of the survey instrument is provided for your review.

Call me should you wish to discuss the extended service hours idea or any other aspects of this report.

Attachment

- Includes headings to serve formal report functions of transmittal and

title page.

- Includes horizontal line to add interest and separate transmittal from body of memo.
- Uses deductive approach to present this periodic report requested by management on quarterly basis.
- Uses headings to highlight standard information; allows for easy update when preparing subsequent report.
- Includes primary data from survey completed by parents.
- Attaches material to memorandum, which would be appendix item in formal report.

Format Pointer

Uses a memorandum format for brief periodic report prepared for personnel within company.